

Searching in Medieval Nordic texts

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IMPORTANT NOTICE: This is a brief introduction to the search facilities for texts in the Menota archive. Please note that the interface is under continuous development, so these instructions may become outdated, at least in parts.

1. Reading texts & making morphological queries in the Menota archive

The Medieval Nordic Text Archive can be accessed without password or registration on the CLARINO website (which contains a number of other corpora):

<https://clarino.uib.no/menota-prod/home>

The catalogues of the archive lists all available texts. They have been encoded at up to three levels, i.e. the facsimile, the diplomatic and the normalised level (indicated by **Facs** / **Dipl** / **Norm** in the table head), but the majority only on the diplomatic level, **Dipl**. The facsimile level means that the text is displayed very close to the source, the diplomatic level that it is slightly normalised (and thus easier to read), and the normalised level means that the orthography has been fully regularised. For the time being, this only applies to Old Icelandic and Old Norwegian texts.

A number of texts in the archive have been lemmatised, indicated by **Lemma** in the table head, and many of these have also been annotated for grammatical forms (case, number, mood, etc), indicated by **Form**.

By clicking any file name in the second column of the catalogue you will be able to read it on screen. If it has been encoded on more than one level, you can watch all levels side-by-side simply by ticking the boxes for **Facs**, **Dipl** and **Norm** below the title line. Several texts also offer photographic facsimiles.

Note that you do not need to have any specific font installed in order to read the texts in the archive, even on the facsimile level. The archive uses a **Web Open Font Format** (WOFF), meaning that a suitable font is being used to display all necessary characters on screen.

Credit: Most of the work on developing the display and search facilities in Menota has been done by Paul Meurer, University Library / CLARINO, Bergen.

1.1 Searching for words in all files ("free text search")

Select **Search** in the top menu bar and decide which corpora you would like to include in your search (tick one or more boxes).

In the field **Search expression** write a word in whatever orthography you like (and expect to be represented in the texts).

For example, write [konungr](#). Then hit **Run query** – and you will get a list of all the 4705 occurrences of exactly this word (in this specific orthography) in the archive. as of 8 April 2024.

Now, in the search field, write [en konungr](#), hit **Run query**, and you will get the 50 examples of exactly this two-words combination.

Continue with the query [en konungr take](#), hit **Run query**, and you will see the 7 examples of exactly this three-words combination.

So there are only 7 examples of this phrase in the archive? Unfortunately not. There are 7 examples of the exact orthographic combination **en konungr take**. If the manuscript has **en konungr take** or **en konungr taki** or **en konungr taki**, they will not come up. In other words, you need to be familiar with the orthography of the sources in order to make good queries.

The result will be displayed in a **Key Word In Context** (KWIC) format, and by clicking on any word here, a dialogue box will pop up, and by clicking on **Show context** in the top line of this, you will be taken to the exact page where the word is located. Note that the text will be shown in the third column; if not, select **Settings** and tick the box for **document** in the first column.

1.2 Searching for words in annotated files

If you want to see all examples of the lemma **konungr** you have to restrict your query to the annotated files. The majority of these are Old Norwegian and Old Icelandic.

In the query field, write: [\[lemma="konungr"\]](#) and hit **Run query**. The result is no less than 8664 hits. This list will include all forms of the word.

Since the annotated files have information about the grammatical forms, you may specify this, if you like, to narrow down your query.

By typing [\[lemma="konungr" & msa=\("cN" "nP"\)\]](#) you get all 84 examples of the lemma **konungr** in [case Nominative](#) and [number Plural](#).

Fine! But you are not happy with the definite forms, so you narrow down your search to `[lemma="konungr" & msa=("cN" "nP" "sI")]`, adding *species Indefinite* to the list, and suddenly you are down to 67 examples.

So what about any combinations of **sá hinn** in the texts, in whatever forms? Just type the query `[lemma="sá"] [lemma="hinn"]`, and you get the 342 examples of these two lemmata (in this sequence) in all their variant forms.

Too much? Only interested in the feminine singular nominative? So type `[lemma="sá" & msa=("cN" "nS" "gF")] [lemma="hinn" & msa=("cN" "nS" "gF")]` and you get the 51 examples of **su hin** (with minor orthographic variations).

Now, are there any forms in preterite subjunctive plural of *fara*? If you type the query `[lemma="fara" & msa=("tPT" "mSU" "nP")]` you will get the 22 examples of preterite subjunctive plural of this verb, irrespective of person – since you did not specify this.

You might add "p1" for the 1st person, however, in other words `[lemma="fara" & msa=("tPT" "mSU" "nP" "p1")]`, and the result is just 4 examples. The order of the categories does not matter, by the way – `("tPT" "mSU" "nP" "p1")` is as good as `("p1" "nP" "tPT" "mSU")`.

From this point, you can make your own searches. Two things are useful to know, however, the orthography of the lemmata, and the grammatical abbreviations.

1.3 Lemma orthography

In the annotation of the Old Norwegian texts, the orthography of lemmas follow the rules of the Old Norwegian Dictionary (Gammelnorsk Ordboksverk). These differ from standard Old Norse orthography in four major aspects:

1. Consonantal *i* is spelled *i*, e.g. *siá*, *kveðia* (not *sjá*, *kveðja*)
2. No distinction is made between *o* and *ø*, e.g. *diofull* and *koma* (not *djøfull* vs. *koma*)
3. The diphthong *ey* is spelled *øy*, e.g. *høyra* (not *heyra*)
4. The *h* is not written before *l*, *n* or *r*, e.g. *lutr*, *nakki* and *ringr* (not *hlutr*, *hnakki*, *hringr*)

More than 5 % of the lemmas are affected by these rules, so if you do not get expected hits on a query, please remember to check these rules once more.

We are planning to bring the *Gammelnorsk Ordboksverk* orthography in line with that of *Ordbog over det norrøne prosasprog*, but this process will take some time.

1.4 List of abbreviations

The abbreviations are for the time being identical with those used in the XML annotation of texts in Menota.

Category	Features				
Person	p1	p2	p3	pU	
Number	nS	nP	nU		
TensetPS	tPT	tU			
Mood	mIN	mSU	mIP	mU	
Finiteness	fF	fI	fP	fU	
Voice	vA	vR	vU		
Gender	gM	gF	gN	gU	
Case	cN	cG	cD	cA	cU
Degree	rP	rC	rS	rU	
Definiteness	sI	sD	sU		

Individual abbreviations

A = accusative	I = infinitive	PS = present
A = active	IN = indicative	PT = preterite
c = case	IP = imperative	r = degree
C = comparative	M = masculine	R = reflexive
D = dative	m = mood	s = definiteness
D = definite	N = neutral	S = singular
F = feminine	N = nominative	S = superlative
F = finite	n = number	SU = subjunctive
f = finiteness	P = participle	t = tense
g = gender	p = person	U = undecided
G = genitive	P = plural	v = voice
I = indefinite	P = positive	

Note that identical abbreviations are never used in the same context; for example **A** means **active** in the abbreviation **vA**, but **accusative** in the abbreviation **cA**.